administration of Sangngachos Dzong. In 1910, the minister in charge of Border Affairs in Szechuan and Sikang, set up commissioners at Sangngachos and Tsayul and sent them on a tour of inspection of the Lower Tsayul area, mainly to guard against British intrusion. In the report submitted by the officials in 1911, it stated, 'The dividing line between Tsayul and Lo Lo is along a stream at Yapichulung at the third stage to the southeast. The British are still farther away beyond Adzara. The name of the place is not known.'

Further 'evidence' provided by the Chinese to strengthen their claim in the Lohit River Valley is a subsequent report by a survey team that charted the area up to Yapichulung: 'On the western bank of Lower Tsayul there are 10 households at Sungkung, 7 households at Sama and one household at Waloon [Walong]...'. After the Revolution of 1911, this area was still under the administration of Sangngachos Dzong. According to the Chinese, it was not until 1944 that it was invaded by Britain.

There is little doubt that China, having colonized Tibet at a time when colonialism was on its way out in the rest of Asia and Africa, based its territorial claims along the Himalayan watershed on what can best be described as the limits of Tibetan ethnography. That the claims made by the Chinese—by far surpassing anything the Tibetans themselves ever staked a claim on—was a process driven by strategic interests. Even before China's invasion of Tibet changed the equation in Asia, an equally important development on India's northernmost border had taken place that had almost gone unnoticed. This was the Chinese takeover of Sinkiang on 25 September 1949 when Nationalist Chinese troops stationed there changed their allegiance to Communist China. This immediately brought the vast expanse of the Aksai Chin into play. There can be little doubt that China decided to contest the McMahon Line in the east as a bargaining chip to secure Aksai Chin in the west.

On December 26 1959, Peking wrote to New Delhi stating that China had consistently said that 'an overall settlement of the boundary question between the two countries should be sought by the Chinese and Indian sides, taking into account the historical background and present actual position'. According to an article by Durga Das, the then editor of the *Hindustan Times*, when Chou En-lai visited India in April 1960, he told Nehru that China proposed a 'reciprocal acceptance of present actualities in both sectors and constitution of a boundary commission'. This statement